

Manoel Island: back to the public, a national park?

*Testing the Prime Minister's statement on the
return of Manoel Island from MIDI*

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

***“We are transforming this area into a national park
designed according to the wishes of the Maltese
and Gozitan people.”***

Prime Minister Robert Abela, 13 May 2026 (as reported by Newsbook).

Said on the day the deed ending MIDI's concession was signed.

VERDICT: SUPPORTED

The return is confirmed; “national park” is a pledge: Not measurable

Version 1.0 · 9 October 2026

Status: draft, pending right of reply

Prepared from public sources.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

On 13 May 2026, the day the Government of Malta and MIDI plc signed the deed that ended the Manoel Island and Fort Tigné concession, Prime Minister Robert Abela said: **“We are transforming this area into a national park designed according to the wishes of the Maltese and Gozitan people”** (as Newsbook reported him). The claim record summarises this as: Manoel Island has been returned to public ownership from MIDI and will become a national park. We checked the return against MIDI’s own stock-exchange announcements and the news reports, and the park against what the law, the Planning Authority and the Government have published since.

- 1

The return happened, and MIDI says so. MIDI’s announcement of 13 May 2026 says a public deed “was today entered into” by the Government, Transport Malta and the company “for the rescission and termination” of the concession over Manoel Island and Fort Tigné, “resulting in the return thereof to Government”. Parliament had approved the agreement and MIDI’s shareholders did so on 28 April [3, 7].
- 2

The return is of the concession area, not every use on it. MIDI keeps the Tigné Point development [4]. A sports ground on the island is being sanctioned for padel courts, and the Prime Minister said the yacht yard was never part of the MIDI concession [12, 13]. None of this contradicts the return; it shapes what “public” means in practice.
- 3

“National park” is not defined in any law we searched. The word does not appear in the six Maltese Acts we searched, including the Environment Protection Act and the Development Planning Act [14]. We found no instrument, plan or local plan change for a Manoel Island national park, and no date. Newsbook and TVM News report that the local plan will be changed and that Heritage Malta is expected to draw up a management plan [1, 2].
- 4

What we cannot tell. We did not read the deed or the shareholder circular, and our searches of the Planning Authority and Heritage Malta were by web search only. A plan may exist that we did not find.



1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim record came from a MaltaToday headline, “Manoel Island officially returned as public land” [locator, page refused to scripts]. Following our rule to quote the speaker, not the headline, we read the readable reports of the signing day (13 May 2026) and the company’s own announcements. The Prime Minister’s words inside quotation marks are quoted below; everything else is the outlet’s text or the company’s announcement.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
Prime Minister Robert Abela , as reported by Newsbook, 13 May 2026 [1]	“We are transforming this area into a national park designed according to the wishes of the Maltese and Gozitan people.” Also: “We have placed the health and time of our citizens before money.” Newsbook says the Government will amend local plans so no development can take place on the island, and that Heritage Malta takes responsibility (outlet’s text).	Read in full, 9 Oct 2026.	The claim (quoted words)
TVM News , 13 May 2026 [2]	Abela called the signing a “historic moment”. TVM reports that the sites “have been returned to the Maltese public” and will fall under Heritage Malta (TVM’s text, not in quotation marks).	Read in full.	Outlet report
MIDI p.l.c. company announcements, 17 Mar, 20 Mar and 13 May 2026 [3, 4, 5]	In-principle agreement for partial rescission of the 2000 emphyteutical deed; reimbursement of €47,321,000, about €43 million net of VAT; the concession over Tigné Point (excluding Fort Tigné) stays in force. On 13 May a public deed was entered into, “resulting in the return thereof to Government”.	Read in full (PDFs; hashes in data/cc-055/documents.csv).	Primary (company disclosure)
TVM News , 17 Mar and 28 Apr 2026 [6, 7]	Lands Minister Owen Bonnici’s figures (€78m asked, €43m agreed) and next steps; Parliament approved the agreement unanimously “last March”; shareholders approved on 28 April. Abela called it another “dream come true”.	Read in full.	Outlet report
Partit Nazzjonalista statement, 17 Jul 2026 [11]	Says no legal guarantee defines what a national park is or what is permitted in it.	Read in full.	Opposition view; tested in section 3

WHAT WE COULD NOT READ

The public deed itself, MIDI’s circular to shareholders of 6 April 2026, the parliamentary resolution, the Office of the Prime Minister’s release and the Planning Authority’s decision on the padel courts were not available to us (gov.mt and parlament.mt refuse scripts; the deed and circular are not linked from the announcements we read). MaltaToday pages return 403; the 21 July remarks are known only through Lovin Malta’s summary of MaltaToday ♦. Routes tried are in *literature/CC-055/README.md*.

2 Method

Questions. (A) Was the MIDI concession over Manoel Island ended and the island returned to the Government? (B) Is the return complete as far as the public is concerned? (C) Is there anything published that makes “will become a national park” checkable?

Evidence. For A and B we read MIDI’s three announcements and the reports of the signing; the dates and the amounts are checked in *calc.py* (data/cc-055/checks.csv). For C we searched the consolidated texts of six Acts on legislation.mt for “national park” and “nature reserve” (Cap. 549, 552, 445, 504, 573 and 623; 9 October 2026) and searched the web, TVM News’s and Lovin Malta’s Manoel Island pages and MIDI’s announcements for a plan, a designation or a local plan change; the search log is in *literature/CC-055/notes.md*.

The limit of C. Not finding a document is weaker than reading one. Subsidiary legislation, the Planning Authority’s consultation pages, Heritage Malta’s website and the e-tenders portal were not searched directly.

Grades. A company’s regulatory disclosure and statute text are grade C (primary, but not independently audited); news reports are grade D and are used to locate what was said. **Verdicts** and **pledge labels** follow Appendix A.

3 What the evidence shows

The return. On 17 March 2026 MIDI announced an in-principle agreement for the partial rescission of the emphyteutical deed of 15 June 2000, so that the concession over Manoel Island and Fort Tigné is rescinded while the concession over Tigné Point (excluding Fort Tigné) stays in force [4]. On 20 March it said the terms had been agreed subject to Parliament and its shareholders [5]. TVM News reports that Parliament approved the agreement unanimously and that shareholders approved it on 28 April [7]. On 13 May MIDI announced that the public deed had been entered into, “resulting in the return thereof to Government” [3]. That is 57 days from the first announcement to the deed.

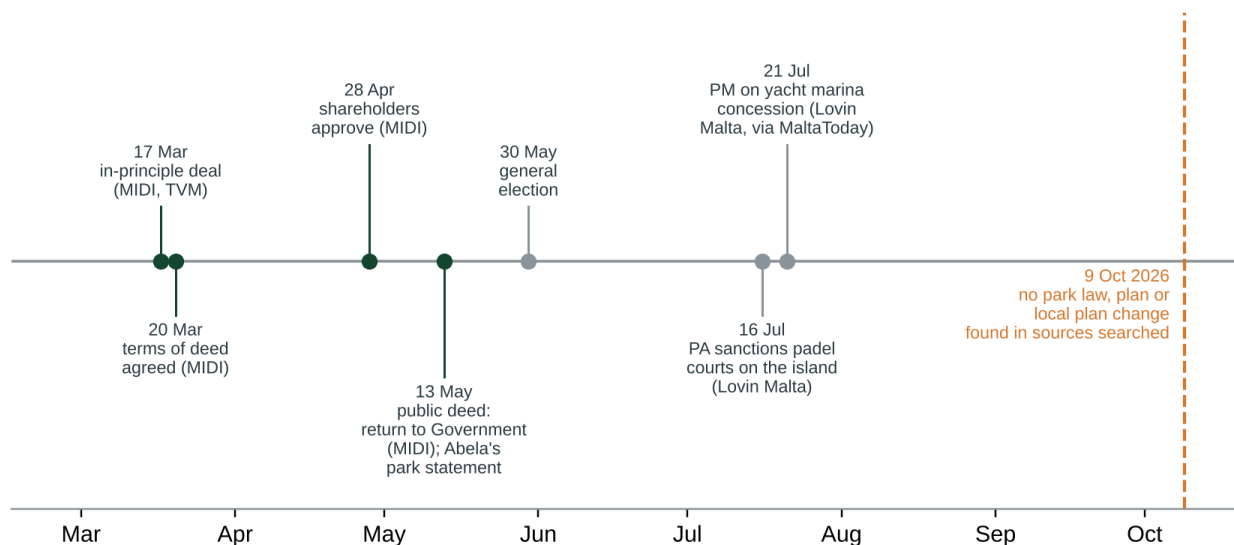


Figure 1. Steps from the in-principle agreement to the deed (green), and later events that bear on the park (grey). Sources: MIDI announcements [3, 4, 5]; TVM News [2, 7]; Lovin Malta [12, 13 ♦].

The cost, for context. The claim does not state a price, but reports differ. MIDI’s €47,321,000 is the gross reimbursement and “circa €43 million” the net figure after VAT [4]; Lands Minister Bonnici’s €43 million is “just over half” of the €78 million MIDI asked for (our check: 55.1%) [6].

What the public now has. TVM News reports the Prime Minister saying that the sites pass to the responsibility of Heritage Malta [2]. Not everything on the island is covered by a park. The Planning Authority approved the sanctioning of 20 padel courts and 10 more on the former Nicholl football ground on 16 July 2026 [12], and the Prime Minister said that area had always been a sports facility and that the yacht yard, on the Sliema side, was outside the MIDI concession [13 ♦]. These are uses within or beside the returned land, not a reversal of the return.

The park. The words “national park” were used by the Prime Minister on 13 May [1] and by the Labour Party that day, which pledged that Manoel Island, White Rocks and Fort Campbell would be priorities in the next legislature [9]. We found no Maltese Act that defines the term: the six consolidated texts contain no occurrence of “national park” [14]. The opposition makes the same point [11]. We also found no published designation, management plan or local plan amendment for Manoel Island, and no deadline. Without a definition or a date, the statement cannot be shown to be met or missed.

WHAT THIS DOES AND DOES NOT SHOW

It shows that the concession was ended and the island returned to the Government. It does not show that no park is coming: the outlets report steps (a local plan change, a Heritage Malta management plan) that may be taken later. It shows only that on 9 October 2026, 149 days after the deed, we could not find them.

4 Where the evidence points different ways

Is Manoel Island on course to be a protected national park?

NO PUBLIC TEST YET

WHAT WAS COMMITTED

The Government ended the concession and took the island back; the Prime Minister has announced a local plan change, and a Heritage Malta management plan is expected [1, 2], after a public consultation that drew thousands of submissions.

WHAT WE FOUND SINCE

No law defines a national park [14]; the opposition says so too [11]. Two months after the deed the Planning Authority sanctioned padel courts on the island [12], and the Prime Minister said a marina concession would be issued by public call [13 ♦].

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

Both can be true. The Government’s commitments are real but undated, and “national park” has no legal meaning against which they can be tested. We rate what was said as Not measurable, not as broken.

5 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. The MIDI concession over Manoel Island ended and the island returned to Government	Prime Minister [2]; MIDI [3]	MIDI’s own announcement of 13 May 2026: public deed, “return thereof to Government”; Parliament and shareholders approved [3, 7].	ACCURATE
B. The return is to the public	Prime Minister [2]	Heritage Malta takes responsibility [2]. MIDI keeps Tigné Point [4]; padel courts and a yacht yard sit on or beside the island [12, 13 ♦]. Deed not read.	ACCURATE, WITH CAVEATS
C. It will become a national park	Prime Minister [1]	No definition in six Acts searched; no designation, plan or local plan change found; no date stated.	NOT MEASURABLE (PLEDGE)

6 Verdict, pledge and requests for evidence

VERDICT

SUPPORTED

The concession ended and the island was returned to the Government, as MIDI’s own announcement states; “national park” is rated as a pledge: Not measurable. Confidence: moderate.

Why. (1) The factual statement, that Manoel Island went back from MIDI to the Government, is confirmed by the counterparty’s regulatory disclosure and by unanimous parliamentary approval as reported. (2) The caveats on public use (MIDI’s Tigné Point, sports uses, the yacht yard) concern what stands on or beside the island, not whether it was returned. (3) “Will become a national park” is a promise, so it is rated under the pledge scale. Confidence is moderate because we did not read the deed or the shareholder circular.

PLEDGE LABEL: NOT MEASURABLE (AS OF 9 OCT 2026)

The pledge as worded has no definition (no Maltese Act we searched defines “national park”) and no date. The label judges delivery against the pledge as worded, not anyone’s intent, and is revisited when a definition, designation or timetable is published.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From the Lands Ministry and Heritage Malta: the public deed and MIDI’s circular of 6 April 2026, and any terms that limit public use.
- ☐ From the Office of the Prime Minister: what “national park” means for Manoel Island in law, and the date by which it is to be designated.
- ☐ From the Planning Authority: the local plan amendment ruling out development on Manoel Island, if made.
- ☐ From Heritage Malta: the management plan, and the consultation report behind “thousands of submissions”.

RIGHT OF REPLY

A reply is sought for the pledge label *Not measurable* (maintainer rule of 5 October 2026). The maintainer handles it; nothing has been sent. Until the deadline has passed this is a draft label on this site only and is not to be circulated elsewhere.

7 Limitations

- The Prime Minister’s words are read through Newsbook and TVM News; the Office of the Prime Minister’s release was not readable. Only words inside quotation marks are quoted.
- We read MIDI’s announcements, not the deed or the circular. MIDI is a party to the agreement and its announcement is a company disclosure, not an independent record.
- Whether “public ownership” in law is exactly “return to Government” was not tested against the deed. We did not check the land registry or the Lands Authority.
- “No national park instrument or plan found” rests on six consolidated Acts (legislation.mt), web searches and two outlets’ Manoel Island pages (first page of results). Subsidiary legislation, Hansard, the Planning Authority and Heritage Malta websites, and the Government Gazette were not searched directly.
- The padel-court decision is read as Lovin Malta reports it; the Planning Authority’s decision was not read. The 21 July remarks are second-hand (♦).
- The pledge was made on 13 May 2026, 17 days before the 30 May 2026 general election; the claim is rated on what was said, not on the party’s motive.

References

- [1] Xuereb M. (13 May 2026). Watch: Agreement over Manoel Island and Fort Tigné signed. Newsbook.
<https://newsbook.com.mt/en/agreement-over-manoel-island-and-fort-tigne-signed/>
- [2] Rossitto A. (13 May 2026). Manoel Island and Fort Tigné agreement finalised to return sites to the public. TVM News.
<https://tvmnews.mt/en/news/manoel-island-and-fort-tigne-agreement-finalised-to-return-sites-to-the-public/>
- [3] MIDI p.l.c. (13 May 2026). Company announcement MDI222: Manoel Island and Fort Tigné (public deed). Malta Stock Exchange.
<https://cdn.borzamalta.com.mt/download/announcements/MDI222.pdf>
- [4] MIDI p.l.c. (17 Mar 2026). Company announcement MDI214: Manoel Island and Fort Tigné (in-principle agreement).
<https://cdn.borzamalta.com.mt/download/announcements/MDI214.pdf>
- [5] MIDI p.l.c. (20 Mar 2026). Company announcement MDI215: Manoel Island and Fort Tigné (terms agreed).
<https://cdn.borzamalta.com.mt/download/announcements/MDI215.pdf>
- [6] Spulber M. (17 Mar 2026). Government reaches €43M agreement to end concession – MIDI requested €78M. TVM News.
<https://tvmnews.mt/en/news/government-reaches-e43m-agreement-to-end-concession-midi-requested-e78m>

- [7] TVM Newsroom (28 Apr 2026). MIDI shareholders approve agreement to return Manoel Island and Fort Tigné to the public. TVM News. <https://tvmnews.mt/en/news/midi-shareholders-approve-agreement-to-return-manoel-island-and-fort-tigne-to-the-public>
- [8] Falzon G. (17 Mar 2026). Manoel Island and Fort Tigné to be returned to public, Robert Abela announces. Lovin Malta. <https://lovinmalta.com/malta/manoel-island-and-fort-tigne-to-be-returned-to-public-robert-abela-announces/>
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- [10] Italtpress/MNA (1 Jan 2026). Malta, PM rings in New Year with pledge to reclaim key sites for public. <https://www.italpress.com/?p=623920>
- [11] Partit Nazzjonalista (17 Jul 2026). Manoel Island: A “national park” only for the election. <https://pn.org.mt/en/?p=29629>
- [12] Falzon G. (16 Jul 2026). Planning Authority sanctions 20 illegal Manoel Island padel courts and approves 10 more. Lovin Malta. <https://lovinmalta.com/news/local/planning-authority-sanctions-20-illegal-manoel-island-padel-courts-and-approves-10-more/>
- [13] Demirci A. (21 Jul 2026). Robert Abela says Transport Malta will issue concession for Manoel Island yacht marina. Lovin Malta, reporting MaltaToday (page refused to scripts) ♦. <https://lovinmalta.com/news/robert-abela-says-transport-malta-will-issue-concession-for-manoel-island-yacht-marina/>
- [14] legislation.mt. Consolidated texts of Cap. 549, 552, 445, 504, 573, 623, searched 9 Oct 2026 for “national park” and “nature reserve”. <https://legislation.mt/>
- [15] Mizien. Calculation script and outputs: tools/cc-055-report/calc.py; data/cc-055/checks.csv, documents.csv.

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Pledge labels

A pledge is a promise of future action, so it cannot be true or false when it is made. It gets one of these labels instead of a verdict, with the date of the evidence behind it.

Pledge label	Meaning
NOT MEASURABLE	The pledge as worded has no definition, baseline or date against which delivery could be checked.
NOT YET DUE	Measurable; the deadline or term has not passed and no progress data have been published yet.
ON TRACK	Published progress is at or ahead of a straight-line path (or the pledge's own milestones) to the target by the deadline.
OFF TRACK	Published progress is behind that path, and the target has not yet been shown to be met or missed.
MET	Documents or data show the target was reached, by the deadline if one was set.
MISSED	The deadline or term has passed, and documents or data that can be shown say the target was not reached.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance, statute text or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.

- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	9 Oct 2026	First issue. Verdict Supported (moderate confidence); pledge label Not measurable; pending right of reply.